

Ok. So I asked this last night but this morning as I woke up I remembered why I used the word "commission" or "commissioned" — so anyway, I really love history, I think it's very interesting, and of my favorite "role" that exists in history of not of a leader/king/sultan/emperor etc. etc. but of their like "right hand" person, their "confidant" bc that person is the upper limit of that leader's abilities, is a representation of them in many ways and knows so much and has to know so much. (I know when I'm that person to someone & I act like it & I know how to recognize that person in a room, like I get it, I get that role and what it's all about, any lab i've ever joined, i recognize that person & know what they're all about). I know Robert Greene wrote that book about Power, it's been awhile, I remember I skimmed through it in the summer of 2017, not everything is about power, there are important people that are advising people in power that don't want power and are like advisors but are super important and history doesn't even mention them (and these have been women too & they're not remembered in history) and they have an enormous (sleepless nights) amount of responsibility. I would argue, that's more stressful at times than being the leader. So, you mentioned, Galileo becoming "He succeeded and became chief mathematician and philosopher to the Grand Duke of Tuscany." He was the pride of the Medici family: was the best, G.O.A.T, he was the "pensioned" court intellectual, and therefore he was the cultural and political ASSET. That's the politics of science. So when you're saying "It resembles competition among modern countries to retain a Nobel Prize-level scientist more than a royal commission. Jacobi was not told, "Solve this mathematical problem for the king." Rather, the state paid and accommodated him because possessing Jacobi himself was a cultural and political asset." He was the pride of the Prussian Empire. He was in a way, for the "state" one of the right hand people — a representation of that Empire's science and technology capabilities, so that's what science and technology is, you are that nation's cultural and political asset. So anyway, that "right hand" person, is suppose to be the wisest & smartest & honest person the person in power should find, they also have to be really street smart & strategic, their goal is, that person in power, wins. When I use to

strategic, their goal is, that person in power, wins. When I use to watch Game of Thrones, bc I think they did a good job at this (and so did "The Tudors" which I watched a long time ago with my friend in undergrad), I would pay attention to what that "right hand" person is doing/saying, more than the main characters/main story line, the closest advisor to the person in power — that's their pride, that's their upper limit, that's the person who can see their blind spots. Granted, Greene talks about "not outshining the master" when that person, who is the leader's "right hand" person, say things that the leader person doesn't like then that person ends up getting guillotined (Thomas Cromwell! I forgot the name I had to look it up, it's been awhile since AP Euro). But anyway, that "right hand" person I think is now the science and technology institutions in countries and attacking them is really crazy, that's a nation's upper limit — but they stemmed from that idea, of finding a problem (bridge needs to be built, let's find the person who is the most capable to doing it and commission that person etc.) So, say, you're a dept chair, and that "right hand" person is practically unlettered, doesn't know what is up, down, left, right, they're just average, at best, but you're parading them around in litigation as something beyond that, and they're not, that's very embarrassing bc again, that "right hand" person, HISTORICALLY that role, is so important and you're not going to go far if that person is useless i.e. "this is the person that is advising you as a dept chair, that's really sad and pathetic bc that person is really dumb — so why are you parading them around as a cultural and political asset when they're not & can't you understand what that says about you? If you chose that person then you're average & you bought it upon yourself your own downfall.

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Yes—your underlying idea is coherent, and the word **“commissioned”** was pointing toward something broader than a one-off assignment. You were thinking about how authority historically **identified, retained, elevated, and displayed capability**.

What you are describing is the politics of **delegated intelligence**: the ruler has formal power, but another person helps determine how intelligently that power can perceive, plan, and act.

The “right hand” is the leader’s operational intelligence

A king, department chair, CEO, or principal investigator cannot personally know everything occurring under their authority. Their closest adviser therefore becomes several things at once:

- an information filter;
- a detector of blind spots;
- a translator between the leader and the larger organization;
- a strategist who converts wishes into executable plans;
- a truth-teller—or, in a dysfunctional system, a flatterer;
- a visible demonstration of what kind of competence the leader recognizes and values.

That is why you watch that person in a room. The official leader may be performing authority, but the right-hand person often reveals **how the system actually thinks**.

Your phrase **“the upper limit of the leader’s abilities”** is insightful, though I would slightly refine it:

The adviser does not automatically constitute the leader’s upper limit, but the quality of the leader’s advisers—and the leader’s capacity to hear them—sets a major limit on the intelligence of the regime.

A brilliant adviser whom the leader continually ignores cannot rescue the leader. A brilliant leader surrounded by people who conceal information will also become functionally stupid. The actual ceiling is something like:

adviser quality × leader receptivity × institutional honesty

If any one approaches zero, the entire decision-making system deteriorates.

There were historically several versions of this role

You are combining roles that sometimes belonged to one person but were not always identical:

The confidant knew the ruler personally and could speak privately.

The chief minister or councillor translated the ruler's desires into policy and administration.

The court favorite possessed personal access but was not necessarily wise or competent.

The technical or learned expert supplied knowledge the ruler did not possess.

The prestige intellectual demonstrated that the ruler's court or state could attract exceptional minds.

Thomas Cromwell approached the chief-ministerial version. He became Henry VIII's principal adviser and helped transform the king's intentions into legislation, administrative machinery, religious restructuring and increased royal authority. His fate also demonstrates the danger you identified: the agent carries responsibility for producing the sovereign's desired outcome, but the sovereign can disown the agent when the outcome becomes inconvenient.  National Archives +2

Galileo occupied a somewhat different position. He was not the Medici state's Thomas Cromwell. He was a **learned ornament, technical authority and source of dynastic prestige**. He deliberately named Jupiter's moons after the Medici while seeking patronage, and he subsequently became Chief Mathematician and Philosopher to the Grand Duke of Tuscany. His discoveries became associated with Medici magnificence: supporting Galileo allowed the dynasty to represent itself as intellectually sophisticated and cosmically significant.  High Altitude Ob... +1

Jacobi was farther still from being a personal "right hand." He was not advising the Prussian king's daily political decisions. But your broader interpretation works: as an eminent mathematician retained within the Prussian university system, he represented the state's ability to cultivate and possess first-rate intellectual capability. The state was supporting **the person and the prestige-producing capacity**, rather than purchasing a predetermined theorem.  Pasted text

So I would call Galileo and Jacobi something like **prestige-bearing intellectual assets**, rather than literal right-hand men. They occupied the same larger political ecosystem—the conversion of exceptional knowledge into state prestige and capacity—but performed a different function from a Cromwell, vizier, chancellor or chief minister.

Modern science institutions are the institutionalized version

Your next move is especially interesting: in modern states, the “wise adviser” has partly ceased to be one individual and has become an **institutional network**.

Universities, national laboratories, statistical agencies, scientific advisory bodies, public-health institutions and research funders collectively perform functions that once depended heavily on a ruler locating a few extraordinary people:

- preserving specialized knowledge;
- detecting realities political leaders cannot directly observe;
- testing whether claims are true;
- forecasting threats;
- developing technical capacity;
- training the next generation of capable advisers;
- advising the state without requiring every leader to be a scientist.

The postwar United States explicitly developed a government–university research partnership on the premise that research institutions served national interests. Federal agencies became major supporters of university research, while government reports treated research universities as part of the country’s strategic scientific capacity. NCSES +2

So yes: attacking those institutions indiscriminately is not merely “being hostile to academics.” It can amount to damaging the state’s **capacity to know things**. It blinds the ruler rather than merely insulting the adviser.

The important distinction is that modern scientific institutions should ideally be more resilient than a single court intellectual. Their usefulness comes partly from distributed expertise, professional standards, replication, disagreement and institutional independence. They are not supposed to function merely as decorative geniuses telling the sovereign what he wants to hear.

What an incompetent right hand communicates

Your department-chair example follows the same logic on a smaller scale.

A person whom the chair repeatedly places forward—as adviser, spokesperson, institutional representative, witness or defender—becomes an extension of the chair's judgment. Observers reasonably ask:

“Out of all the available people, this is whom you selected to understand the situation, advise you and represent your decisions?”

If that person demonstrably lacks the relevant knowledge, judgment or credibility, several interpretations become possible:

- 1. The chair cannot recognize competence.**

This is the most damaging interpretation because choosing advisers is itself a leadership competency.

- 2. The chair values loyalty over truth.**

The person may be useful because they are compliant, not because they are capable.

- 3. The chair is informationally isolated.**

A weak adviser may filter out criticism and tell the chair only what preserves the relationship.

- 4. The chair is attempting to manufacture prestige.**

Institutional titles, legal positioning or public display are being used to create an appearance of authority that the person's actual knowledge cannot support.

- 5. The chair's own abilities may have been overestimated.**

Leaders generally select people they can understand, trust, control or recognize as valuable. A sustained inability to distinguish substance from performance is evidence about the leader—not merely the subordinate.

That is why the mismatch feels embarrassing to you. The chair is not only presenting that person. They are inadvertently presenting **their own criteria for judgment**.

There is, however, one caution in the litigation context: being prominently used in litigation does not necessarily mean the institution considers someone its wisest or most capable adviser. Legal teams may emphasize a person because they possess particular facts, occupied a relevant role, signed documents, implemented a decision, or can advance a specific legal theory. Litigation is strategic representation, not a transparent organizational ranking.

But where the institution is making a broader claim—"this person was competent, authoritative, reliable, central and acting with sound judgment"—then the person's evident inadequacy does create a second-order problem:

The institution must now defend not only what that person did, but why its leadership trusted, elevated and relied upon them.

The darkest version of the right-hand relationship

The best adviser is not simply the cleverest person. They must possess enough honesty to tell the principal something unwelcome and enough political intelligence to make the truth survivable.

That is the tension you recognized through Cromwell and Greene. The adviser must improve the leader without making the leader feel displaced. They must see farther while preserving the leader's sense that the final vision belongs to the leader. Under insecure authority, competence itself can become threatening.

That is also why mediocre right-hand people sometimes survive longer than brilliant ones. They do not expose the leader's limitations. They reassure the leader, absorb blame, enforce preferences and make the principal feel comparatively impressive.

Such a person can therefore be very useful **to the leader psychologically**, while being disastrous **for the institution epistemically**.

So your argument is not merely:

"This right-hand person is unintelligent."

It is the stronger institutional argument:

"By selecting, trusting and publicly elevating this person, the leader has revealed the quality of their own judgment, the kind of information they tolerate and the ceiling they have imposed upon the institution."

And yes—when the supposed cultural, technical or political asset cannot withstand scrutiny, parading that person around magnifies rather than conceals the leadership failure.